First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 10
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Flow
8 November 2026

LVF Updated 21 October
Needs Communion Liturgy
COMMUNION

Preaching: LVF
Worship Leading: ML & …

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Michael and … to center chancel]

Welcome **ML**

Words of Gathering **ML &**

Celtic wisdom looks for the flow of the divine
deep within everything that has being.
It is like a subterranean river coursing
through the veins of the universe.
If somehow it were dammed up or stopped,
everything would cease to exist.

This sacred flow is not simply a dimension of life
that may or may not be there,
depending on the moment, the place,
the person, or the species.
It is the very essence of everything that exists.

On this day, let us awaken and look for the flow
of the Divine deepen within all things
and then, release it to ourselves
and one another. [jphilipnewell]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn Of Gathering** ***For the Beauty of the Earth DIX

For the beauty of the earth, for the splendor of the skies,
For the love which from our birth over and around us lies,
God of all, to you we raise this our hymn of grateful praise.

For the wonder of each hour of the day and of the night,
Hill and vale, and tree and flower, sun and moon, and stars of light,
God of all, to you we raise this our hymn of grateful praise.

For the joy of human love, brother, sister, parent, child,
Friends on earth, and friends above, for all gentle thoughts and mild,
God of all, to you we raise this our hymn of grateful praise.

For the good that love inspires, for a world where none exclude,
For a faith that never tires, and for every heart renewed,
God of all, to you we raise this our hymn of grateful praise.

[Michael center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness **ML**

Holy One, in this sacred space, we bind unto ourselves today -
the virtues of the star-lit heaven, the glorious sun's life-giving rays,
the whiteness of the moon at even, the flashing of the lightning free,
the whirling winds tempestuous shocks, the stable earth, the deep salt sea
around the old eternal rocks.
Help us in this time to weave together
spirit and matter as we seek the Divine
around us, among us, and within us.

[adapted from, The Prayer of St. Patrick hymn]

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

[... to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**
Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace** **ML**
As we share this ancient greeting,
we invite you to offer signs of peace to one another with a bow
- a gesture used broadly across many cultures
as a sign of greeting, respect, honor, humility, and love.
This morning, may it be an expression
of the intention of the peace with which we long to live
with one another, the world, and all creation.

All things come from you, O God,
and to you we return.
All things emerge in your great river of life
and into you we vanish again.
At the beginning of this day
we wake
not as separate streams
but as countless currents in a single flow
the flow of this day's dawning
the flow of this day's delight
the flow of this day's sorrows
your flow, O God,
in the twistings and turnings of our days.
[jphilipnewell]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[... to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition ***from the Gospel of Mark***
Hear now this reading from the Good News According to Mark…
A person with leprosy approached Jesus, knelt down and begged,
"If you are willing, you can heal me."
Moved with pity, Jesus stretched out a hand, touched the person with leprosy

and said, “I am willing. Be cleansed.”
Immediately the leprosy disappeared, and the person with the disease was cured.

Jesus gave a stern warning and sent the person off. “Not a word to anyone,”
Jesus said. “Go off and present yourself to the priest and make an offering for your healing as Moses commanded, as a testimony to the religious authorities.”

But the person who had been healed went off and began to proclaim
the whole matter freely, making the story public.
As a result it was no longer possible for Jesus to enter a town openly,
and Jesus stayed in lonely places.
Even so, people kept coming to him from all directions.

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Michael to center chancel]

Prayers with the People **ML**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

[Pause, then begin]
In ancient times, the Celtic people would gather around their fires,
and together, they would find assurance in looking at the heavens
and remember what they knew in their hearts -
that new beginnings can grow out of seasons of shadows and death.

Like our ancestors, we can know the connection between nature and grace,
between the movement of the spheres above and our inner landscape of soul,
and we can imagine fully awakening to the sacredness of the universe
and one another in this space.

It is in such faithful imagining together that we will help bring about
what we are most deeply longing for, a resurrection of harmony
in our lives and our world.

As we enter into these moments of silence,
may we be grateful for the gift of this time.

Silence

[2 minutes of silence, then Christoph transition out of silence]

Prayer of our Hearts

It is in the depths of life that we find you
at this heart of this moment
at the center of our soul
deep in the earth and its eternal stirrings.

You are the Ground of all being
the Well-Spring of time
womb of earth
the Seed-Force of stars.

And so at the opening of this day
we wait
not for blessings from afar
but for You
the very Soil of our soul
the early Freshness of morning.
Time and eternity intertwined, heaven and earth inseparably
woven together, the sacred flowing deep in the matter earth
and the human mystery. [jphilipnewell]

Amen and Amen.

[Christoph transition for Laude]

Meditation Anthem

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon ***Sacred Flow*** **LVF**

[Christoph transition as Michael & Laura go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings **LVF & ML**

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith, or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we

remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[... to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

Each week we come into this sacred space
and give thanks for the wonderful gift of reflective awareness
that allows us to recognize and name the presence
of the Creative Spirit beyond all imagining in our universe.

Everything we have,
everything we see,
everything we do,
everyone we love and everyone who loves us
reveals this Illuminating Presence
and our bonds with each other
that reach across the globe.

We are so grateful that together, in this place and time, we are on the way to something unknown, something new, as we reimagine our faith.

A faith that is grounded and centered in the presence of our Good and Gracious God,
who loves us more than we can imagine.

We invite you to join us in this ongoing task, by giving from your resources for the work within and beyond these walls.

You will find information for online giving in your programs and appearing on your screens at home. Our Hospitality Team will also come forward now to receive your offerings. Thank you for your ongoing generosity through the resources, time, and talents you bring to strengthen our community to be the Love of the Divine in the world.

Offertory

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[... to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**
Holy One, as your life flows through the rivers and streams of this earth,
remind us on this day, that your life also flows through us.
With these offerings we offer our thanks and praise
and ask that the Spirit of Life, Love, and Goodness
to move freely in our words and actions.
Awaken in us, the possibility of new life, new vision,
and renewed meaning and purpose
as we follow in the steps of those
whose faith continues to flow
around us, among us, and within us.

Thanks be to you, O God.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church **LVF & ML**

Words of Blessing **LVF**
May the deep blessings of earth be with us.
May the fathomless soundings of seas surge in souls.
May boundless stretches of the universe echo in our depths
to open us to wonder
to strengthen us for love
to humble us with gratitude
that we may find ourselves in one another
that we may lose ourselves in gladness
that we may give ourselves to peace.

Choral Response

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn for the Journey** ***Come, See the Fullness BUNESSAN
God the Creator gave in abundance
all of the wonder we now behold;
colors of glory, everyday beauty,
echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open your hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
to your great kindness given to all.

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music - Dr. Ianthe Marini